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The Weight of Remembrance in Poem 3 of *Mythistorema*

“Remember the baths where you were murdered.” That abrupt title is how George Seferis starts Poem 3 of *Mythistorema*, immediately forcing the reader with an accusatory and dramatic tone towards this poem before it even begins. The title on its own is a command towards an unclear subject; the second-person “you” is unidentified, thus making the murder being clear but without context. However, when the first lines shift to “I woke with this marble head in my hands,” the poem transitions towards an individual consciousness, eliminating ambiguity that was developed through the title to what the reader realizes to be a private burden while reading the poem. Additionally, there is a recurring language of fragmentation—“broken,” “mutilated,” “neither open nor closed”—which forces memories of wounded parts that are unforgettable. In fact, Seferis creates this instance of remembrance as a violent demand graphically dragged upon the individual, suggesting that memory isn’t always a voluntary condition with your past but sometimes brutally imposed. In Poem 3 of *Mythistorema*, it is revealed that remembering can be a form of psychological entrapment. The poem doesn’t kindly invite reflection, it forces it—making memory coercive which is showcased through the person being unable to separate his trauma from the “marble head” they are holding.

The title of the poem doesn’t begin with a description but with an imperative, and the verb “Remember” immediately helps establish memory as more so a command rather than a choice. It assumes a past event without explaining it while also providing violence without any

narrative context. The reader is segued into this poem not as an invitation towards reflection but ordered into it and puts them into an already existing wound. This becomes more clear throughout the poem as we uncover the trauma of the individual with it being often fragmented and is more rather than unfolding calmly. However, the more ominous aspect is the second-person “you,” which remains undefined. This line does not clarify who was murdered, when, or why, however, it instead presents the violence as already known as the subject is being reminded of something they should already obviously know. This lack of context intensifies the pressure of the command because the memory must exist even if there aren’t any narrative details prior to explaining it. The passive structure—“were murdered”—positions this poem into immediately underlying the idea of victimhood before the poem’s opening. Through withholding an explanation while insisting on recollection, Seferis makes this scenario of memory into accusation. The individual does not discover trauma gradually, they begin even before the poem begins—through the title. The command of the title structures the entire poem because it precedes any narrative, identity, or explanation. The memory comes first and any understanding of the individual's self or reasoning unravels second. The title does not simply refer to past violence, it recreates and reminds a disoriented, traumatic memory by commanding recollection of it without context.

“I woke with this marble head in my hands; / it exhausts my elbow and I don’t know where to put it down.” The shift from the title’s accusatory second person to this private revelation doesn’t end the violent tone but transitions it onto the body. Going into this first-person consciousness does not provide more clarity to the reader but only intensifies the title’s command to remember. The marble head is not seen in an imaginary manner or at a distance; it is literally being held, and more importantly, it creates strain to the individual. The

verb “exhausts” changes the implications the title employed to the reader to rather highlight physical exhaustion which suggests that the past is not just remembered but clearly burdensome. Since the head is detached from its origin, it is incomplete and this matters because it signifies a broken origin. The weight is both strenuous to the individual and also a fragment from the original location. Furthermore, when the speaker confesses that he does not know “where to put it down,” the person is unable to let aside the object, thus, implying that the past cannot simply just be set aside. By being unable to let the marble head go, the poem further emphasizes that even despite the burden it carries, the individual can’t move on. This is proved even to a greater extent in the line “so our life became one,” where the distinction between the external object and the person’s self become inseparable. The marble head does not only symbolize some type of assumingly traumatic memory but restructures the person’s understanding of themselves by binding him to a past that exhausts him. Despite this, there is no effort of separation seen which serves to showcase that memory can be coercive and destabilizing. The title forces remembrance, and the marble head implies a burdening past. However, Selferies underlying objective is to highlight the fusing of the object and one’s self to highlight the difficulty to let go no matter how taxing it may be.

The fragmentation that starts with the marble head ultimately extends to the speaker himself. As they study the object, they describe the features but realize that their physical features are suspended: the eyes are “neither open nor closed,” and the mouth “keeps trying to speak.” These details reveal a resistance towards functioning. The eyes exist in between awareness and blindness, and the mouth is between speech and silence. Their past cannot fully actualize and articulate itself but there is an attempt of refusing to remain still. Nevertheless, is it still hopelessly complicit. The details of the marble head doesn’t stop there but rather becomes

increasingly more bodily with details of its cheeks that have “broken through the skin” evoking torn flesh rather than a smooth marble stone. The language towards the object is no longer characterized as just an artifact but shifts into anatomy. This is important because in the beginning of the poem, the marble head is still just an object, heavy and burdening but still just a thing. Thus, Selferies is implying that the past is separate from the speaker just as the individual is to the marble head. However, as the diction becomes more anatomical, the vocabulary describes the marble head as if it has flesh, wounds, failed speech, and damaged skin. It stops just being a stone, it starts behaving like a living thing and even injured. This is important because by humanizing the marble head, Selferies is effectively collapsing the boundary the reader initially thought between the object and body. The final lines of this poem complete this revelation: “My hands disappear and come towards me / mutilated.” The violence announced in the title is now no longer without context but rather something that has become internalized. The speaker does not just hold something that is fragmented, they are the broken one. Throughout the course of this poem the past does not remain to be just an object of a memory but reshapes itself into the present body of the speaker which then integrates the marble head and themselves. What began as a sudden imposing act of remembrance cultivates in an unraveling realization of physical and psychological discombobulation. Revealing memory to be a force of nature that fragments one’s identity itself. By making the realization that individuals themselves were the fragmentation rather than observing the marble head’s attributes, Seferies effectively share that memory and especially traumatic ones are both things that cannot be let go but if impactful enough, can even fragment one’s identity. The speaker no longer becomes the one holding something broken but realizes they are the broken ones.

Although *Mythistorema* is a collection of twenty-four poems, many of which often speak in a plural manner “we,” Poem 3 isolates the experience of memory within a singular “I.” I found this shift to not be incidental and intentional which is why I choose to analyze this poem specifically. The movement between a collective voice to a private consciousness suggests that while the past might be shared amongst a community, confrontation towards it is dealt alone. The poem represents that the strain and memory might be produced, physically and psychologically or otherwise, is beared to one body at a time. Seferies implies that remembrance cannot be resolved collectively, rather it must be endured individually. Poem 3 reveals the cost and burden at the level of one’s self. This poem ends on an unsettling notion, while the past could bind communities, its wounds are carried alone.

Work Cited

Seferis, George. "Mythistorema." *Collected Poems*, translated by E. Keeley and P. Sherrard, Princeton UP, 1995.